Preface to the Commentary

This project attempts to apply a "literary conversion function" to the Five Books of Moses - with a focus on the Book of Genesis - so that the result is an entirely different story: the story of human culture.
The "conversion function" is a kind of **dictionary**, in which every concept (e.g., water, earth, animal, human) has a specific **cultural** meaning.
When the Five Books are read through this prism, the story turns from a mythological tale about the development of people and dynasties into a story about the development of human culture: from the hunter-gatherer stage, through the first civilizations, the development of religions, and into the modern era.
(The commentary focuses on the Five Books: the Prophets and the Writings seem not to be part of this.)

The intention is to build a system **with logical rigor**, as opposed to a **flexible** allegorical system in the style of "Drash" (דְּרוּשׁ).
While Drash has a high degree of freedom (the preacher allows himself to create connections and interpretations freely), our allegorical commentary is unique relative to the vast Drash literature, in that it tries to be a system with as few degrees of freedom as possible. The principles that follow from this are:

1. **Adhere to the text and to the dictionary:** if the dictionary interprets a certain word in a certain way, then the biblical text must be interpreted exactly that way.
2. **A compact and coherent dictionary:** the dictionary itself must be compact - with few definitions, and with the expectation that even these few definitions are coherent with one another (e.g., since the concepts `אדם` (human) and `חיה` (animal) are close, the definitions of `אדם` and `חיה` are expected to be close as well).

The Dictionary (The Literary Conversion Function)

The dictionary contains only **primitive definitions**: concepts whose meaning cannot be derived from other concepts in the dictionary or from root analysis. Derived concepts (such as נחש, קין, הבל, and most of the characters and places) are established within the commentary segments themselves.

Concepts of Light: Thoughts

- **אור** (light) / **ראייה** (seeing) = contemplation, public discourse, the activation of a kind of "collective consciousness".
  Light and seeing may remain at the level of awareness, not yet fully named (see "saying = naming" below) - not necessarily crystallized in a coherent way.

- **חושך** (darkness) = existence and activity "on autopilot" - without thought or analysis.
- The day cycle "...←בוקר←יום←ערב←לילה←בוקר←..." parallels the **Hegelian** model of dialectic and synthesis:
  1. **בוקר** (morning) - from בקרה (examination, review): an examination that leads to the crystallization of a dialectic - thesis and antithesis. This leads to -
  2. **יום** (day) - the dialectic generates public discourse, introspection, and searching. This leads to -
  3. **ערב** (evening) - as in שְׁתִי-וָעֵרֶב (warp-and-weft, weaving) - synthesis and the integration of the insights. This leads to -
  4. **לילה** (night) - a "quiet" period between dialectics - processes that take place without public discourse: automatic activity, or even the maturation of insights "from below" - without open discussion. And this leads to morning, in an endless cycle.

Concepts of Speech: The Ideational / Theoretical Layer

- **אמירה** (saying) / **שמיעה** (hearing) = naming (giving a name), identification, articulation.
  "Saying" is the naming of a new concept or process, and "hearing" is the internalization of a saying that comes from outside.
  The act of saying is so consequential that stories can sometimes be summarized through the sequence of sayings within them.
  Saying - the giving of a name - is what makes genuine public discourse possible: discourse without adequate names is "crippled" discourse.
- **קריאה** (calling by a name, or calling to someone) = the institutionalization of an idea in the culture's consciousness - as something future developments can rely upon (**sedimentation**).
  Saying creates an idea - and some ideas are "called": they become a built-in part of the culture.

For an extended treatment and the connection to modern concepts - see דיון על אמירה וקריאה.

Sky and Earth: The Subconscious Experience of Existence

- **מים** (water) = chaos, the unknown, the threatening, the promising. The chaos may come from outside - from events in the world - or from within - from emotions and drives: a force that bursts in upon us and is beyond our control.
  Water is both menacing and yearning, and it pushes the culture to act. Hence water also symbolizes motivation (fear/aspiration): water is needed to achieve change and development, and without water, stagnation sets in (per the dictionary: **death**).

- **ארץ** (earth/land) = the experience of existence: the basic **subconscious** way in which a culture understands itself in relation to the world - an intuition of how the world operates around it.
  The names of specific places represent different systems of existential experience.
  The following proverb nicely illustrates the concept of "ארץ": "You can take the boy out of the village, but you can't take the village out of the boy" - the experience of "who I am in relation to the world" was shaped and imprinted in the child's soul in the village environment, in a way that the experiences of the big city struggle to erase.
- **שמים** (sky/heavens) = the basic **subconscious** way in which a culture understands the boundary between "us" and "the terrible outside": between what can be manipulated and what is beyond reach.
  Literally and technically - שמים is "שָׁם מים" ("there - water"): there lies the terrible outside - absolute chaos, beyond any control.

The Material World - A Scale of Complexity

- **צומח** (vegetation) / **אכילה** (eating) = insights/models about the world. Without eating (the internalization of new insights), bewilderment, confusion, and an inability to act develop (per the dictionary: **רעב**, hunger).
- **יצורים** (creatures - animals and humans) = a story/narrative that the culture tells.
  Creatures usually have a **נפש** = a tendency to preserve themselves (see linguistic analysis).
  The נפש is usually "חיה" (alive) (see the definition "**חיים** = dynamism and change" below): the נפש usually tends to adapt and change according to circumstances and needs.
  - **חיות** (animals) = a "local" narrative - a non-authoritative narrative: one of many narratives that exist within a culture.
  - **אדם** (human) = an **authoritative** narrative of a culture: a narrative that a culture enforces upon itself in order to forge an integral identity.
    - **אישה** / **איש** (man/woman): the split between elite and popular - with an emphasis on the solidarity and intimacy between them (בראשית ב:כג - `עֶצֶם מֵעֲצָמַי וּבָשָׂר מִבְּשָׂרִי`).
    - **נקבה** / **זכר** (male/female): the split between elite and popular - with an emphasis on the sharp gap between them:
      - **זכר** (male) = an elite narrative - a narrative that sees itself as the one that dictates to and leads society (see linguistic analysis).
      - **נקבה** (female) = a popular narrative that accepts upon itself the dictates of the זכר (see linguistic analysis).

Important Additional Definitions

- **אלהים** = a kind of indefinable force that pushes the world to develop in a certain direction - like the Hegelian concept "Weltgeist". Possibly derived from the preposition "אל" (toward) - as in "אֵלֶיהֶם".
  יהוה = the experience of reality. Probably derived from the root "היה": הָיָה הוֹוָה וְיִהְיֶה (was, is, and will be).
  יהוה אלהים = reality in its entirety - both the experience of how things are (יְהוָה), and the developmental force that pushes them in a certain direction (אֱלֹהִים). Literal reading: "reality *that is also* directed".
- **כל** (all) = the tendency to **totalize** - to explain the entire whole. This is an important and central motif.
  Counter-intuitively - when the text says "כל X", the meaning is "the *totalizing* X" (i.e., the X that aspires to totalize everything) - and *not* "all the X's that exist"!
  For example, כָּל הַחַיָּה (per the dictionary - חיה = narrative) means "narratives of the totalizing kind - narratives that aspire to explain the whole of their domain" - and not "each and every narrative".
  In other words: "כל" is not a quantity but a quality - it signals that this X aspires to totalize the whole of its domain.
- **אדמה** (soil) = the general population in the relevant context. The אדם (a specific culture) is built from a *patch* of soil: וַיִּיצֶר יְהוָה אֱלֹהִים אֶת הָאָדָם עָפָר מִן הָאֲדָמָה.
  עפר (dust) = the individuals that make up a society: כִּי עָפָר אַתָּה וְאֶל עָפָר תָּשׁוּב.
- **טוב** (good) = things that *feel* right and worthy. Usually - things that are desirable according to social morality - the right path that society expects a person to walk.
  רע (bad/evil) = things that *feel* unworthy. Usually - things that are forbidden according to social morality - behaviors that society considers immoral.
  לדעת (to know) = to form an opinion about something, to actively pin something down - to tell it: "you are such-and-such" - to label it, to stigmatize it.
- **חיים** (life) = dynamism and change.
  מוות (death) = stagnation: an inability to respond, to adjust, and to change.
  (**הרג** (killing) is very different from death: killing is when the נפש fails - when a story fails to adapt to a new reality - usually due to pressure from a competing story.)
- **The height axis** (למעלה / למטה ↔ על / תחת - up/upon ↔ down/under) = the axis of **agency** - the capacity to act upon something:
  - **מעל** (above) = what acts upon us and what we cannot act upon: beyond reach, dictating, sublime.
  - **מתחת** (below) = what we act upon: within reach, subject to our handling, taken for granted, routine.

- **The weight axis** (כָּבֵד / כָּבוֹד ↔ קַל / קָלוֹן / קְלָלָה - heavy / honor ↔ light / disgrace / curse) = the axis of **mass**:
  - **כבד** (heavy) = something imposing, hard to move, impossible to ignore. Honor.
  - **קל** (light) = something of trivial value, easy to move - something one need not reckon with, something one may dismiss.
- **פנים** (face; פָּנֶי, עַל-פְּנֵי, לִפְנֵי) = in-the-way-of, according-to-the-principles-of, what is already known about something.
  אחור (back, behind) = in another or unknown way, hidden and unknown.
  (Fun fact: in ancient cultures, the image was: the front is what you see - that is, the past; and the back is what you cannot see - that is, the future. Today the image is reversed: the future is in front of you, and the past is behind you.)
- **בית** / **אוהל** (tent/house) = (a place - related to "ארץ") a "comfort zone" - familiar modes of thought:
  ישב / **בא** (came/sat) = settled into a comfort zone.
  קם / **יצא** (went out/rose) = left a comfort zone because of a need or a crisis.

Further Definitions

- **רכוש** (property) = food + animals.
- **מלך** (king) = a human that rules over many humans: an "overarching narrative" that serves as the common denominator - a title - of a cluster of related cultures, and that enables a collective identity - a kind of confederation of cultures.
  עיר (city) = the cluster of people ruled by the king.
- **ברוך** (blessed) = an experience of holiness, something greater than life itself: something perceived as ideal, something people look up to.
  ארור (cursed) = something perceived as dystopian, as a terrible state.
- **מלאך** (angel/messenger) = "a messenger without a name" - a foreign, incomprehensible narrative (sometimes from outside - from the heavens) that comes and interacts with an אדם (a culture).
- **אש** (fire) = a clear and absolute idea, that has no water in it (no room for motivation and change).
  זבח / **מזבח** (sacrifice/altar) = (related to fire) the understanding of something as ideal: the sanctification and canonization of a state.

The Right Way to Approach the Translated Stories

Every segment of biblical text is translated into a cultural-sociological story.
The emphasis in these stories is on fundamental changes in "how the culture understands itself": in relation to the world and in relation to its own identity; in its coping with the conditions of reality, and in the shaping of its ideals and aspirations.
Every story describes a **deep change of perception** - a change of identity, new insights about

the world, the development of new currents and sub-cultures - changes that serve as the basis and prelude for the changes of the stories that follow.
The sequence of stories fits the Hegelian model of cyclical dialectic and synthesis very well.

The Dialectic of Historical Description

The right way to view the sequence of translated stories is as a quality history book - one that copes with a dialectic between:

- The aspiration for a **chronological** description: chapter after chapter - period after period - each chapter a comprehensive description of its period.
- The aspiration for a **depth** description: illuminating deep currents that cut across periods.

A quality history book balances these aspirations: each chapter and each segment focuses on certain deep developments, while the book as a whole advances along the timeline.
Like a mischievous child on a hike - going wherever his feet take him - yet ultimately advancing along the trail.

The Divine Presence

Surprisingly, the translated stories are at one and the same time **entirely secular** (the stories contain no divine presence whatsoever) and **entirely sacred** (the stories are pervaded by divine will).
In this sense, the biblical text is a wonder and a testimony: a text entirely detached from - and also deeply woven into - the divine.

The Intellectual Challenge

One can think of the sequence of translated stories as a history book focused on the cultural-sociological plane.
This history book **will never contain** "earthly" events such as wars, geography, or any concrete-technical aspect of reality.
Instead, the stories will describe the **consequences** of these technical events on the cultural-sociological plane: for example, how a great war affects the experience and worldview of the culture.

It turns out that the intellectual challenge of "severing the earthly cables" is extremely difficult, and requires time and adjustment.
Again and again, you will have to cut the lines drawn by the plain meaning of the text, and keep only the lines drawn by the translation.
This is not a simple challenge at all... prepare yourself for frustration. All beginnings are hard - and this is a great and wondrous journey.

A "Pure" Translation - or a Translation Onto a Specific History?

The most important and central component of the commentary is the translation of the biblical text into a coherent, developing cultural story: a **purely archetypal** story - one that can be "dressed" onto different historical sequences, in different times and places.

Seemingly, one could settle for this component alone - but no.
It turns out that a purely archetypal translation feels "milky" and thin, without emotional involvement, and - surprisingly - it does not make it possible to understand the subtleties of the text.
It turns out that when the story is dressed onto a specific, familiar history, the emotional charge - the emotional meaning of that history - illuminates the translation in a much richer light.
In addition, for some reason and surprisingly, precisely when the story is dressed onto a specific history, key words in the text - words that seem like meaningless ornaments - become meaningful pivots of understanding: suddenly the historical story becomes deeper, more complex, and yields wisdom of life and new insights.

In addition - and very surprisingly - the commentary seems to succeed in being dressed onto a continuous, chronological history, across the longest of time spans.
This success is in itself impressive in terms of reducing degrees of freedom, and impressive on the critical level.

The methodology is to try to keep the two layers separate - as far as possible:

1. The **important, primary** layer is a purely archetypal translation, that can be "dressed" onto different historical sequences, in different times and places.
2. A **secondary** layer is the dressing of the story onto a specific history. Despite being secondary - this layer carries a depth and richness that the primary layer is unable to give.

The Internal Division of the Biblical Text

There are clear cutting points in the biblical text, between three sequences:

First Sequence: The Seven Days of Creation

This very short sequence serves as an introduction - as an overview of what culture is and how it develops. It is an entirely archetypal and pure sequence: an anthropological overview of the classic development of a human culture - at the highest and most general level.
The story of creation has a special importance - because it helps to deeply understand the basic concepts of the dictionary: light and speech, sky and earth, plants, animals, and humans.

Second Sequence: The Story of the Development of General Human Culture

This sequence contains the biblical text from the story of the Garden of Eden to the story of the Tower of Babel: the Garden of Eden, Adam and Eve, Abel and Cain, Noah and the Flood, the Tower of Babel.
The commentary "translates" this sequence into an archetypal story of the development of universal human culture - from the most basic level, to a high and developed culture.
The dressing of these stories onto history will be - with apologies - with a distinctly Eurocentric bias. Presumably they can also be dressed onto other major cultures.
TODO: there is room for work here: finding dressings onto other cultures

Third Sequence: The Story of the Development of Judaism

This sequence begins with Terah's journey to the land of Canaan, through the stories of the patriarchs and the tribes, up to the exile in Egypt, the exodus, and the journeys in the wilderness.
The commentary "translates" this sequence into the story of the development of **Jewish** culture throughout history - from ancient Judaism, through the various periods, and into the future.
It seems that this sequence - the longest one - is itself divided into several sub-sequences.

"Holes" in the Text

The goal is to translate the biblical text "completely": word by word.
But the text also contains mute, broken areas, whose voice is not heard - texts that the dictionary fails to breathe life into:

- Genealogies: this one begat that one begat that one. There is one word per person - which allows an interpretation with too many degrees of freedom. A worthless translation.
- Numbers: as of now - there is no unified methodology for translating numbers (except for the numbers one - unique, two - recurring, and seven - oath and eternity).
- "Reconciling" (apologetic) texts: texts that can be seen as explanations of, and answers to, critical questions. For example: if there was a flood - then how are there animals in the world? The answer: all the animals were in the ark.

The entire space of { the genealogy of Seth, the stories of the Flood and of the Tower of Babel } is saturated with genealogies, numbers, and reconciling texts.
The translation of this space is of low quality. Nevertheless - I chose to translate the stories of the Flood and of the Tower of Babel. It seems that there are "survivors among the ruins": that there is a living, speaking text among the ruins.
There is, within me, an experience of sorrow and pain when I caress these texts.